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PUSAT PENTADBIRAN KERAJAAN PERSEKUTUAN
62530 PUTRAJAYA**

KERTAS PENERANGAN (*INFORMATION SHEET*)

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TAHAP / LEVEL	4 (FOUR)	
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TAJUK/TITLE: PROMOTE GOOD NETWORKING

TUJUAN/PURPOSE:

This Information Sheet is intended to describe the promotion of good networking skills within organization and its related usage. The person who is competent in this CA shall be able to effectively utilize management relationship capabilities.

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PENERANGAN/INFORMATION:

1. Business Networking

1.1 Business networking is an effective low-cost marketing method for developing sales opportunities and contacts, based on referrals and introductions; either face to face at meetings and gatherings, or by other contact methods such as phone, email, and increasingly social and business networking websites.

1.2 The term 'networking' could be misinterpreted and get the wrong impression about with that of computer networking or networks, which is totally different terminology, relating to connection and accessibility of multiple computer systems.

1.3 A business network of contacts is both a route to market for you, and a marketing method. Business networking offers a way to reach decision-makers which might otherwise be very difficult to engage with using conventional advertising methods.

1.4 In addition, business networking brings with it the added advantage of recommendation and personal introduction, which are always very helpful for developing business opportunities.

1.5 A good network is produced, and networking succeeds by the application of hard work. A network without the hard work produces nothing worthwhile.

2. Promote Good Networking

2.1 The principles and techniques of business networking are mostly common sense. Many of the behavioral principles apply also to business and relationships generally, and specifically to selling, managing, coaching, facilitating, etc.

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3. Networking Methodology.

3.1 When at a networking function or social event, the most commonly subject in question is, “are people naturally drawn to you or do you unknowingly push them away?”

3.2 There are a couple of techniques applicable in pursuing networking procedures.

i) Ready to Engage

Approachability means ‘to come nearer to’. But there is no such terminology so called the approaches or approached. So the first idea to remember is that approachability is a two way street. It is both you stepping onto someone else’s front porch and you invite someone to step onto your front porch.

Although this article will address both sides of the street, here is an example of the former. When you arrive at a meeting, event, party or anywhere in which many conversations will take place, prepare yourself. Be “ready to engage” with conversation topics, questions and stories at the back of your mind ready to go as soon as you meet someone. This will help you avoid those awkward ‘How is the weather’ type of discussions.

ii) Common Point of Interest (CPI)

It is an essential element to every conversation and interaction. Your duty, as you meet new people, or even as you talk to your acquaintances, is to discover the CPI as soon as possible. It connects people to you. It allows them to feel more comfortable talking to you. And it increases your approachability as much as people will be magnetized to you due to the commonality you share.

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A great tip is to ask the right type of questions. You may ask questions that begin with “What is your favorite...” “Tell me the best...” or “When was the last time...” The CPI is almost guaranteed to be discovered.

iii) Flavoured Answers

In the event that one of those fruitless questions like “How is it going?” “What is up?” or “How are you?” comes up, do not befallen into the trap, by just simply answer “Everything is fine”. The word fine is inexpressible and could not be elaborated well. A great technique is to offer a flavored answer to a fruitless question. Instead of using the word “fine,” try word “Amazing!” or phrase “Everything is beautiful.” Your conversation partner will instantly change his/her appearance as he/she smiles and, most of the time, inquire further to find out what made you say that answer. It is beyond expectation. As such, that will offer a true response to magnify the way you feel is a perfect way to share yourself with others.

iv) Do Not Cross Your Arms

Even if it is cold, even if you are bored, even if you are tired and do not want to be there, never cross your arms. It is subconscious non-verbal indication that it hinders their approachability, though it is a practice of many people.

As a result, people will not bother about you. They may have the impression that you are defensive, nervous, judgmental, close minded or skeptical. Generally, people would not want to approach someone of that character. Some saying, body language speaks louder than words.

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v) Do Not Assume

Whenever you assume there is tendency to make mistakes. How often do people utter the following sentences?

- You must be new here.
- How is work going?
- Do you remember me?

Bear in mind, just because you meet someone you have not seen before, does not mean he/she is new. Or just because you are at a networking meeting, does not mean everyone in attendance has a job. And for sure, not everyone you remember, remembers you.

Approachability is a function of comfort, so it is important to sidestep these moments of embarrassment with 'success sentences'. These are phrases that allow the other person to offer you the information needed. Examples include, "I am not sure we have met before", "What are you working on this week?" and "I am Mamat, we met last month at the Club meeting."

vi) Options for Communication

Your friends, colleagues, customers and coworkers will choose to communicate with you in different ways. Some will choose face to face, some will email or call, while others will do a little of everything. The bottom line is, make all of them available. On your business cards, email signatures, websites or marketing materials, let people know that they can get in touch with you in whatever manner they choose. You might prefer email, but what matters most is the comfort of the other persons and their ability to communicate effectively.

A good idea is to give people as many options to contact you as possible. There is nothing more annoying to a person than when

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he/she discovers that he/she cannot get a hold of you except via emails.

vii) Email Signature

Whatever applications you use for email find out how to customize your signature. There is nothing more frustrating than receiving an email from someone who wants to talk further, get together or have you send them something that does not have any personal information in the email. So at the end of every email you send, always cross reference the following information:

- a) Name
- b) Title
- c) Company / Organization
- d) Mailing address
- e) At least two phone numbers
- f) Fax number
- g) Email address
- h) Website
- i) A sentence or two about yourself, your company or your job

Think of it this way: have you ever received a handwritten letter from someone that had no return address stamped on the envelope?

viii) Always Have Business Cards

Have you ever told a story about a successful, unexpected business encounter that ended with the phrase, "Thank God I had one of my business cards with me that day!" If so, that is great. You are practicing approachability by being 'easy to reach'. If not, you have missed out a valuable relationship and opportunity. It happens, where people forget cards, or get exhausted of the cards

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or change jobs and the card is yet to be available. The bottom line is; there is a time and place for networking, any time and any place. Just be ready all the time, because you never know whom you might meet.

ix) No Fear

They will not say hello and will not show any interest in you. This is the number one reason why people do not start conversations. However, practice will make this fear fade away. The more often you start conversations, the better you will become at it. So, be the first to introduce yourself or say hello. When you take an active move instead of a passive role, your skills will develop and there will be less of chances being rejected. Also understand the gains vs. losses. For example, what is there to lose from a rejection by someone you do not even know him/her.

x) Wear Your Nametag

There are so many complaints about wearing nametag, and all of them can be validated. Case in point:

- | | |
|--|--|
| a) Nametag look silly
else is wearing them
too | Yes, it does. But remember, everyone |
| b) Nametags ruin my
clothes | Not so if you wear it on the edge of your
lapel or use cloth-safe connectors like
lanyards and plastic clips. |
| c) I already know
everybody | No you do not. You may think you do,
but new people come in and out of
businesses and organizations all the
time. |

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- d) But everyone already knows me No they do not. Even the best networkers know there is always someone new to meet.

Your nametag is your best friend for several reasons.

- a) A person's name is the single context of human memory most forgotten. And people are less likely to approach you if they do not know or forgot your name.
- b) It is free advertising for you and your company.
- c) Nametags encourage people to be friendly and more approachable.

4. **Networking Strategy Development**

4.1 Consider that all sorts of professional people outside of the business community can also be very helpful networking contacts, say, scientists, lecturers, educators, councilors, etc. When developing your networking plans, think beyond the people you'd typically see at other business networking events. Some of the most important connections are not business people, and consequently you need to be creative in reaching them. The examples of networking situations or methods below may provide some help.

4.2 The following tips apply broadly to any sort of business networking, be it face to face, organized events, business social networking websites, etc. The principles are:

i) **Elevator Speech**

It is so called as if you were to meet a potentially important contact for the first time in an elevator at a conference and he/she asks you: "What do you do?" You have no more than 20 seconds, perhaps just

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10-15 seconds, between floors to explain and to make such an impressive impact that the person will ask for your contact details.

Use these principles also in text-based descriptions for the web and printed materials, etc. If you talk or write too much, the listeners or readers will become bored, or think you are rude or too self centered. Describe yourself concisely and impressively. You will demonstrate consideration and expertise by conveying your most relevant points in as short a time as possible.

Here are the main points for creating your elevator speech:

- a. **Your Name** My name is Mr So and So. Look at the other person in the eye with smile. Shoulders back. Speak with confidence. Sincerity and passion are crucial in making a strong early impression.
- b. **Your Business Name** “I work for Rabbit Farm Sendirian Berhad”. In loud clear proud again. Never ask "Have you heard of us..?" or wait for recognition.
- c. **Base and Covering Area** “My company based in Malaysia and my operation covers the whole East Coast region of the state”.
- d. **Your Specialisation** Be different and special and better off from your competitors in some way or the other. Be meaningful for the event or situation or group, and as far as you can guess, be meaningful for the contact. Express what you offer in terms of positive outcomes for those you help or supply, rather than focusing on technical details from your own viewpoint. Load

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your statements here with special benefits or qualities. Be positive, proud and ambitious in your thinking and expression of what you do. Include in this statement what your aims are, to show you have ambition and that you know what you are seeking from network contacts.

Depending on the situation, aim to complete your explanation in less than 20 seconds. Remember, less is more: lots of powerful points in very few words make a much bigger impact than a lengthy statement.

It is a sign of a good mind if you can convey a lot of relevant impressive information in a very short time. Conversely, a long rambling statement shows a lack of preparation, professionalism and experience.

While talking look at the other person in the eyes, and be aware of his/her body language to gauge for interest and reaction to you personally, in order to help your assessment of the other person's character and mood. And this will help you in ending your conversation. Many ways you may ask him/her, for example; any interest in him/her out of your brief clarification.

Many highly competent people have a habit of interrupting and cutting short discussions when they see an opportunity. This means you may not always finish your elevator speech, in which case allow the discussion to progress, rather than try to complete what you planned to say. Be prepared at any time to respond effectively to an interruption.

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ii) Be Different

Differentiate yourself. Aim high and be the best at something. If there is no special difference between you and other providers, then people have no reason what so ever to revert to you. If there is none, find a way to create one. Sometimes this is merely a matter of redefining or placing different emphasis on what you already are.

iii) Help Others

You must give in order to receive. Be helpful to others and you will be helped in return. Networks of people are highly complex. In general it is not possible to see exactly how and why they are working for you, so you must trust that goodness is rewarded, even if the process is hidden and the effect takes a while. Just simply use the principle of 'what goes around comes around'. You should think of this as karma in business.

A possible explanation of how this karma or coincidence produces positive outcomes is found in the rule of 'cause and effect', or the scientific law that states 'every action has an equal reaction'. Good deeds and helpfulness tend to produce positive effects. They are usually remembered and often repaid.

Helping others extends far beyond your personal specialism or line of work. Networking is about working within a system or group of people to enabling relevant high quality introductions and cooperation, which eventually produce great results for the participants.

iv) Personal Integrity

Integrity, trust and reputation are vital for networking. Always keep your integrity.

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Sometimes a situation arises which tempts us to do the wrong thing, causing harm or upset that could have been avoided. Making such a mistake can damage personal integrity. Mistakes happen. If you do make a mistake or wrong decision, whether it significantly undermines your integrity or not, always admit it and apologize. Failing to apologize for wrong-doing often damages a person's integrity and reputation far more than the original misjudgment itself.

Simple mistakes will lead to some integrity lost. Repeating it again and again will cause all integrity gone. People of low integrity sooner or later find that the only friends they have are those people of similar character as he is, low integrity.

Significantly, integrity is vital for trust to develop. Trust is simply not possible without integrity. Building trust is essential for growing a strong network. Lack of trust prevents successful networking. Certain connections are absolutely impossible to develop until a very high level of trust is established.

Empathy and effective listening greatly assist the process of building trust. These qualities require you to be genuinely interested in others; to listen properly, and to reflect back meaningfully and helpfully.

There are people who always keep their promises and commitments. They never make a commitment which they cannot fulfill it. Reliability and dependability are highly valued qualities in relationships, especially when involving referrals and recommendations, because someone's reputation will be at stake. That does not mean you are always available to everyone. It just simply when you say something you mean it and you will do it.

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v) Relevant Targets

Identify the groups and contacts which are relevant to your aims and capabilities. Relevance can be classified in different scopes and areas of interest, for example:

- a) Geography
- b) Size
- c) Sector
- d) Social grouping (e.g., ethnic, gender, age, seniority, etc)
- e) Political or religious grouping
- f) Trade or society grouping
- g) Profession. academic or technical grouping
- h) Specifically organized networking / referrals groups
- i) Other common interest (e.g., social enterprise, environmental, Fair Trade, etc)

The more relevant your targeting of groups and contacts, the more useful your meetings and referrals will be.

Within most networks people tend to have a few close and trusted connections. Choose your most trusted and closest associates, very carefully. Reputations are built according to your selected contacts, in addition to how you yourself behave. So focus your efforts on groups and associates of integrity, as well as relevance.

vi) Plans and Aims

It is important to know exactly what you want, because you were to be asked you should know the exact answer for it. An activity which has no clear planned outcomes is liable to be pulled in all sorts of discarded subjects.

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If you are yet to know what to plan, then there is necessity to do some research. Your research may lead you to the followings;

- a) When evaluating and choosing a potential networking group, especially if dealing with big community, try to obtain some tactics that commonly used by successful members. Acquire some leading indicators from relevant sectors. This will help you assess the group's relevance to your needs and strengths.
- b) You may save much of wasted time by doing some research before committing valuable time to deeper involvement.
- c) A plan is vital because in managing a networking can be a very time-consuming activity.
- d) Have some measurable targets and monitor its results closely.

Here is a simple example for planning and monitoring networking, which extends the elevator speech template above. Just use the headings as a guide if you prefer to work more intuitively, or if you favor certain types of planning method.

Particulars	Group 1	Group 2	Group 3
Target / Aim			
Ideal Connections (People)			
Group Name and Type			
Group Profile / Sector / Interests (Relevancy)			
Tactical Group Notes / Tips (what works well)			

Elevator Speech (For each group)			
What can be done for these people			
What can be achieved from these people			
Diary Dates / Scheduled Tasks			
Targets / Expectations			
Actual			
Time Spent			
Compare with other marketing activities			

Figure 1: Sample Networking Planner

Note

- Alter the box sizes to suit your needs.
- The framework can be extended to manage specific follow-ups etc.
- Decide on your groups or limitations. For a start you may want to pick one business networking website, and one face-to-face networking group or event, and see how it goes before increasing the activity.
- To sustain your focus and efforts, it would be best to limit networking works in a more concentrated manner. If you go on too many groups and networks at the same time you will be spread too thinly, and find it difficult to make an impact in any of them.

vii) Follow Up

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Keep track and do follow up meetings and referrals make things happen. There are two main reasons for the importance of following up.

- a. Networking only produces good results when it is followed up.
- b. Following up with contacts builds trust, reputation, and relationships.

Networkers who meet people and never follow up are wasting their time. Follow up is a matter of relevance and commitment. If a contact or referral is not relevant just ignore it. If there is relevance, follow it up, in whatever way is appropriate for the situation.

If there is lack of relevance and you may think it is a waste of time to proceed with meetings and follow up with referrals then re-examine your group targeting strategy. You might be chasing the wrong groups and connections, and may be you need to redefine the issues.

viii) Be Positive

Be a positive influence on everyone and everything. Use positive language. Always smile. See the superior part in people. Keep your emotional criticisms of others and personal hang-ups to yourself. Speak ill of no-one. Remain objective. Be passionate and enthusiastic, but not emotional or subjective. Be known as a really positive person. It rubs off on others and people will warm to you for being so.

Keep tolerance, patience, calmness and serene, especially when others become agitated.

Seek feedback and criticism about yourself and your ideas from others. It is the most valuable market research you can obtain, and it is totally free of charge.

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Followers gather around people who remain positive and calm under pressure, and who resist the herding tendencies of weaker souls.

At many networking events and situations you will have the opportunity to give a presentation to the assembled group. This is a wonderful chance for you to demonstrate your expertise in your specialized area, your positive confident character, and also to pass on some useful information. During presentations in these circumstances, avoid giving a hard-selling pitch, unless you are sure that such a style is appropriate. Usually it is not. Aim to inform and educate audience rather than to sell. In many networking situations a strong selling presentation is regarded as insulting by those present. This is especially so if you are a guest of a group that you would not normally meet regularly. You will sell yourself best by giving helpful information in a professional and entertaining credible manner.

Be confident, positive and enthusiastic, but do not let this develop into pressure on the audience, or a sense of your trying too hard.

Try to find and present within your specialization the most helpful information for the group concerned. Your aim at the end of the presentation is for the audience to have learnt something useful about your area as it applies to them, and to have been impressed with your professionalism and command of your subject.

ix) Sustained Focused Effort

Be focused and ever ready at all time. All forms of marketing benefit from strongly focused activity. This is necessary for reasons;

- a. To create awareness, and
- b. To build relationships

Much effort will produce much greater results when applied consistently in a strongly focused way. The same amount of effort

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spread over a wider activities, especially if spread over time too. In networking, where occasional participation rarely penetrates the usual inner core of members, but regular enthusiastic involvement inevitably gains attention.

Opportunities should also be continuously open to unplanned networking, which can arise at any time. Paths can cross in the most unexpected places. You will find and develop connections in these unplanned situations if you:

- Make eye-contact with people and smile
- Take the initiative
- Start conversations
- Generally adopt an open friendly approach to everyone
- And always carry a pen and some business cards

Thereafter in both cases, the planned and unplanned, much depend on what you offer to your associates. Networking is full of people with many connections but little of value to offer. Hence, they achieve poor results. Good results come instead from being friendly and open, taking the initiative, working hard at sustaining genuinely helpful contributions wherever you meet people.

In face-to-face networking there is often a 'clique culture', in which members are defensive or sometimes seemingly arrogant. This often indicates a requirement to become known and trusted, which takes time and effort. Networking, like any other activities, requires concentrated effort to produce good results. If you treat networking like an occasional or purely social activity it will not produce superior results.

Networking requires sustained effort to make things happen. Sustained focused effort means working hard to become a regular

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active helpful presence in the group. Build relationships first, your reputation next, and referrals and introductions will follow.

Question

1. What is business networking?.
2. What is the most common subject item posed at networking function?
3. Why does approachability so called a two way street?
4. What do you understand by Common Point of Interest (CPI)?

References

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